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Spatialities and the feeling of doing

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Recent discussions of non-representational theory and expressive/sensuous embodied practice have provided new orientations for rethinking how people live and feel,¹ and inform notions of spatialities and lay geographies. These arguments I develop in this paper through a consideration of an ethnography of recreational caravanning in the UK. I consider how spatialities may be developed in practice in relation to a refiguring of contexts and embodied semiotics.

Key words: embodiment, practice, space, spatialization.

Introduction

My attention focuses on two concerns. One concern is to understand the processes through which people encounter the world in its complexity, spatially. The second is to understand and to interpret how such encounters may be used in making sense of that spatial world, its contexts and representations. These concerns are considered through their informing, and being informed by, the spatial working of human identities and subjectivities.

I discuss these dimensions through the creative tension between contextual representations and embodied subjective practices in a critical interpretation of culture *and* subjective human spatialities in everyday life. Using an ethnographic investigation of caravanning in the UK I explore people's accounts of what they do and what they make of what they do, their tactics, imagination and movements, in

relation to cultural texts and other resources on which they may draw.

Everyday practices 'need no sanction from on high' (de Certeau 1984) but *we* need them to grasp what cultural geography is. In discussing methodology I explore my effort to grasp understanding of spatial subjective practice where the geographer may or may not share the very processes s/he claims to investigate and to make conceptual sense. I begin my discussion by reflecting on two dimensions of current debate: embodiments; and practices, knowledges and spatialities.

Orientations

Embodiments

A critique of spatialities has developed in terms of embodied contexts of practice in terms of

body as object and the inscription of culture/power/ideology through which space is grasped, culture reproduced, focused and recycled through representations (Bourdieu 1984; Grosz 1992; Young 1990). Thus the inscribed body may define the limits of subjectivities, difference and identity (Grosz 1992: 243). Whilst external rules and sanctions may be felt to define and delimit, the self-practice can be liberating and subversive with the body's subjective boundaries (Game 1991; Teather 1999: 15; Young 1990: 11).

In contrast, 'non-representational geographies' conceptualize the body as sensuous, sensitive, agential and expressive in relation to the world, knowing and innovating amongst contexts and representations that become refigured in practice (i.e. not *oppositional* to representations) (Pile and Thrift 1995; Thrift 1996, 1997). The subject lives her body and lives the world through that body (Csordas 1990, 1993; Thrift 1996).

Thereby our contact with the world can be considered a multi-dimensional encounter and can express emotion and relationship with it, through inter-subjective body-communication (Crossley 1996; Goffman 1971; Merleau-Ponty 1962; Radley 1995; Thrift 1997). The individual moves, speaks and experiences space through and in relation to the body and its body-space, the immediate metaphorical and material space of doing things. The feeling of being together can animate the space (Nielsen 1995). The body is rendered *involved* in the world in which it extends itself metaphorically, transforming the space, *flirting with space*.

Kristeva suggests that the body's existential immediacy or felt multi-dimensional relationship with the world can provoke imagination and its translation into different feelings and spatial intimacies. Thus bodily drives are never totally repressed. The subject remains always *in process*, expressed in movement of the body

as often wilful, in voice, rhythm and laughter (1996; see also Sharpe 1999). de Certeau talks about poetic encounters and the limitless imaginative translation of space in a playful, child-like free-thinking (1984), acknowledging the possibly romantic practice that the body can engage and provoke through its potential to disrupt mental rationality through bodily encounter. That *feeling of being* can be practised as 'feeling of doing', a means of grasping the world and making sense of what it feels like, the 'feel' at once and mutually physical *and* in a process of 'making sense' (Harre 1993). The world may be felt *and discovered*, partly (re)constituted through this process, and 'made sense'.

Practices, knowledges and spatialities

This everyday capacity of geographies contrasts with arguments of some postmodern geographies that the world is apprehended through decoding free-floating signifiers (Crang 1996). Reflexivity is usually discussed as mental process (Lash and Urry 1994), and MacNaghten and Urry argue 'our senses cannot be trusted to interpret the dwelt-in world' (1998: 236). However, in the same postmodern condition embodied agency may be seen as a component of wider contemporary reflexivities in the (re)making of the self, identities and relations with the world. Game emphasizes the body's sensuality in the making of reflexive identities through her bodily encounter with the world, making 'her own' significations (1991).

Subjectivities and knowledges of places and their networks may be constituted through friends' networks and mobilized by humour, for example in a *subjective practice* of buying things (Gregson and Crewe 1997; Jackson

1999; Miller 1998). The content and context of, for example, imported cultural resources such as music may be profoundly refigured through cultural interchanges at street level and be thereby potentially empowering (Wall 2000). This raises the possibility of a diffuse micro-politics as the subject carves through contextualities in grasping the world. Domosh acknowledges the potential of everyday micro-politics in practising alternative relations, human capacities and geographies (1998; see also Gorz 1984).

Approaching practice from the different embodiment theories may be a less competitive than complementary means through which it may be possible to get closer to the constitution of spatialities. Space may be considered a site of subjective exploration, creating space in a way that challenges *a priori* assumptions as to what 'context' is and how it works—or is worked—in practice (Barnett 1999). Places can serve as contexts and constraints, but also as creative possibilities in relation to human practice and its imagination. Contexts may be problematized by investigating processes of making sense of space through practice.

Spaces, like bodies, are inscribed upon. We may 'look' at spaces and seek out those inscriptions (Lash and Urry 1994) and practice may travel along pre-figured channels unless disrupted by ideology (Macnaghten and Urry 1998: 211). However, rather than spatialities being prefigured in representations and contexts through which human subjects encounter space, Clifford (1997: 54) and de Certeau (1984) suggest that they may be developed *in practice*, ontologically, discursively made sense and felt in an embodied way. It is through these plural elements of embodiment, practice, knowledge and spatialities that the following ethnographic investigation is developed to explore the processes of lay geographies.

Methodologies; ethnographic practice

UK recreational caravanning provides the fieldwork through which these ideas are explored. This approach was informed by previous experience researching allotments to explore and interpret a practice (felt) marginalized in culture (Crouch 1999). What sense do we make of practices amongst people who seem simply to want to get on with their lives? Caravanners meet in a field. The field has not only semiotic significance, perhaps, for the subjects, but also anthropological, spatial and research-method significance, as discussed at the end of this paper.

Three researchers spent twelve weekends caravanning. Shared identity is, of course, problematic in the inevitably ambiguous, possibly 'in between' situation of the researchers (Katz 1994: 67–72). None were *caravanners*, although one had lived in a caravan for two years. Our ages were thirties and forties; one woman, two men; each has a partner. We were invited to join in activities yet our feelings of doing were not necessarily to be equated with our subjects as they were familiar with what to do, how to relate, and so on. In this way we both *othered* ourselves and felt *othered*. The subjects of the spatialities we investigate did not invite us to do the work, yet we sought to encounter them (Kobayashi 1994: 73–80; Nast 1994: 54–65).²

Caravanning alone tended to hinder conversation because most caravanners attended as families, or with partners, so we began to go together with our partners. Caravanners seem to be 'straight' and 'ordinary' people, and seek to present themselves as such to cope with their own 'othering' in popular culture. Pulling an awkward and rather anti-*style* box along the road and parking in the country has produced popular attention and disdain (Crouch 1997; Crouch and Ravenscroft 1995). Against this

they feel the necessity to appear as 'normal' as possible, hence they may 'other' New Age travellers with whom they can be bracketed. The caravanners we spent time with included lower middle class largely self-employed, those working in mid-tier service industries, others in 'new service' positions (medicine, education) and the early retired from manufacturing or road haulage jobs for health reasons.

Research interviews extended across a series of activities and spaces, including a pub, barbecue, going for walks, playing games. This enabled a flow of conversation between groups of varying size, different exchanges, and some checking of narrative. Making encounters was a very varied experience, given our (in)competences and differences. We felt difficulty in encountering because our subjects were 'on holiday'; enjoying themselves, or so they said. Encountering in this way inevitably disrupts, detracts and can formalize.

Our subjects had distinctive responses to us. Some felt that we were there to understand formalities and structures, using us as the object of their promotion, an opportunity to settle stereotypes. Others provided only technical information partly perhaps to conceal their feelings, or to work out their identities, partly because they felt safe with conversation of that kind, perhaps feeling otherwise threatened. Others who felt we were out of place, sought to make one researcher 'comfortable' and to feel accepted. Amongst several women whose partners were also enjoying a drink in the pub, he felt 'mothered'. Many people enjoyed chatting and found it interesting to reflect on what they were doing. On several occasions we were invited back. Another response was to 'other' mercilessly. One researcher, sitting calmly in a chair around a table for tea was approached by one caravanner wearing many decorative chains and being pulled by a dog 'trained for man-work' and asked what he was doing. The

man answered, 'you must be fucking mad'. Although notes from fieldwork are used in the narrative their use is problematic because these are inevitably 'not-you' (Katz 1994). Yet we too act as human beings, feel discomfort, fun, human relations, behave practically and feel romantic. Thirty household interviews in three areas (Essex, South Yorkshire and Weardale) were made, each up to two hours and sometimes continued to include other people as they joined, and produced data that was transcribed and coded.

Fields of practice

Objects, actions and spaces

The spaces in which caravanning happens are explored through numerous material objects: barbecue equipment, chairs, flags, water buckets, trees, fields, corners. The caravan's small space can be felt to be both restrictive and safe, shut off from complexity, or complex in a practice of reassurance installed with home features. ['It's nice to be away from the humdrumness of life at home' (Ann, Weardale 1996)]. Children are felt to be safe. The van (caravan) is felt significant: 'it's good to have the van parked outside during the winter, it reminds you of last summer's memories and helps you look forward to the next' (Geoff, Essex 1998).

Many caravanners feel that the van enables you to 'go where you like when you like'. That phrase appears in club magazines. This van is a place to shelter from the storm and an icon of freedom tinged with romance (Creswell 1993). It provides a means of mobility and of temporary dwelling, convenience and romance. Some of our subjects regarded it as *a means to an end*. Magazines frequently remind of revered heritage in the autobiography of a Victorian

gentlemen who travelled Britain in a horse-drawn caravan (Stables 1886).

The van positioned in the field is the most significant object around which cultural capital can be expressed ('There are always people who want to play "Jonese's" and look out whenever someone arrives with a new van' (Denis, Yorkshire 1998)). Objects can provide contested ground of what people are doing and their relative competence. Cultural capital can be a component of the aesthetization of the caravan in advertisements, with vans adorned by models in romantic locations and the familiar cream vans are superimposed on paintings of Seurat and Whistler, emerging as objects of beauty in the Bois de Boulogne and along the Suffolk coast (Eldiss 1997).

However, to reduce objects to only a practice of social/cultural positioning would be to ignore the nuanced complexity of what people do and how they express their feelings. The van is a marker of events through which different feelings may be expressed. Two women talk over how they came to use ornaments in their vans:

I started putting ornaments in the van because of Sarah. She kept saying 'fancy coming here with a van and not having anything of your own inside'. She dresses hers up with ornaments. It becomes a bit of a mickey-take. You dress it up like at home. You take the dressings with you. (Sheila, Essex 1996)

The use of ornaments includes reference to the domestic everyday, maybe objects of humour and friendship, and assert 'ownership' on the space.

Barbecue provides a physical focus for eating together, happens in public space. It is visible, strongly smelling, audible. People gather and turn to each other, making the fire, in conversation and laughter, one-upmanship, use the chance to meet and tell stories of the day's

events and of previous rallies. Moving around people share memories. State-of-the-art equipment and exclusive use of gleaned 'natural' materials, twigs in an old dustbin, make different cultural capital. Attending the fire and sorting food attract a lot of fun where people can celebrate being away from home. Objects are used to demarcate space and their meaning, to shape relations. The caravan field is the place where this happens:

In the middle of the field there is a group of vans. We have a barbecue and good booze. All you need is a few vans, a bit of a field. (Mick, Essex 1997)

Relationships and the space and features of the site become animated in activity where contact with the ground can be very physical. People tell stories of dragging a car out of the mud; pulling a van up a slope, crossing a torrential river on the way to bingo, of children enjoying getting 'lost' in the streams between the high grass; of people 'slumping down in a chair'.

Spaces and activities are mixed in talk about memories:

Dad didn't have much money and we always went camping for holidays. We used to go by bus and walked a lot. I get my memories from childhood and camping, which is another important thing, the memories you stored up. If it were hot you'd put orange juice in the river to cool. (Alec, Sheffield 1996)

The complexity or confusion of 'home life' can be replaced by a relaxed detachment when it happens in the small, 'easily cleaned' space of the van. The simple awkwardness of the van is different from what is possible at home, tolerated because time is unsettled and also limited; there is a sense of being able to cope.

Towards the end of a rally people gather, hear stories, news, applaud competition win-

ners at the 'flag ceremony' where flags depicting the local club are given as prizes. This takes place in a space set aside between caravans. Flags may be placed on show outside a van as a story of previous weekends. The flags can provide very visible cultural capital and an expression of a desire to meet others and to share stories: 'people always come up and ask you to give your stories about where you've been, what it was like' (Rob, Essex 1996). These actions and the spaces where they happen can be understood through relationships. These various corners and spaces can be important in the autobiographies constructed during the weekend.

Spatial proxemics/imagined communities

'Just a field, and my mates' (Jock, Essex 1997). People talk about equipment both with interest in buying them and in having a chance to chat and to share enthusiasm (Moorhouse 1992). Repairing vehicles is a familiar subject of conversation, intensified if someone has an unfamiliar model. 'Doing a van' can provide a chance to meet somebody, to share time:

At one rally this bloke steamed up with a cloud of smoke coming from his bonnet and I fixed him ... Another time we ran over and dragged a van out of the mud in the corner of the site. 'That's another friend you've made'. (Fred, Yorkshire 1996)

These events happen in parts of the overall caravanning site, partly allocated in the arrangement of parking vans, partly through the more messy, chaotic arrangements between vans with the paraphernalia that people make themselves in and between which they do things.

Individual time tends to be balanced with time together, sometimes in an exercise of free-

dom and inter-dependency. In the Sheffield district a somewhat stronger sense of 'membership' referred to a tradition of rambling, camping and cycling in working-class South Yorkshire. The desire to be alone need not interfere with a romantic sense of identity amongst others. Various spaces may be encountered during the weekend, where different feelings of friendship are felt important.

Here you're not on your own but surrounded by other people. We have always tried to do our own thing during the day, like walking, and meet up at night-time. We go across and join the others for a get-together. It's like a global family. (Graham, Sheffield 1996)

Two aspects emerge here. They experiment with spaces and with each other. They move around, talk; imagine communities in terms of 'mobile village', 'temporary village'. Such spatial and social metaphors include reference to particular spaces used and how they are used and in relation to their feelings about other people. The 'community' can be felt oppressive; several families referred to their 'time away' on their own every few weekends, 'but we're always glad to get back' (Ed, Essex 1997, 1998).

Some people keep a van in one place (a 'static site') through the year to visit periodically. Caravanners share space and meet doing similar tasks, but also connect with their wider sense of locality. 'We always try and go up to the pub every weekend that we are here; the wife goes regularly to the local bingo', often with an ambiguity of 'membership'. Some people say they find more friendship, more chance to 'fit in', and more identity than they can find 'back home'. Being a 'static owner' inscribes difference from *temporary* 'rally people' (the tourers) conferred less by commitment than by stability. The touring vans occupy a distinct

part of the site and the tourers organize themselves. We found no mutual antagonism, although barbecues are usually organized separately, at different times to suit their distinctive schedules.

However, even at a rally not everyone takes part and sometimes friendship merges with exclusion. One group of people identified a small number of caravanners allocated spaces at the far end of the field, ignored, reputedly having 'transgressed club rules' some years previously. Sociality can be claustrophobic, exclusive and divisive, the site rendered a space of control, demarcated according to different friendships, or none. Some people changed their club membership in order to join one with a more friendly reputation.

Different groups with shifting membership merge and re-form:

I come because Sarah is coming, so that we have a social evening away from home. You can sit in the corner and say 'sod the social life', we always go to the social evenings, a give-and-take part of it ... It's socializing isn't it, that's what I enjoy, the fact that you can relax and unwind without the hum-drumness of being at home, without the ties. (Sheila, Essex 1996)

There is a commingling of an imagined, almost utopian community and people getting along together in a variety of ways, in physical proximity in particular spaces (Maffesoli 1996).

Outdoors

The 'outdoors' can be ambiguous and can animate particular 'rural' expectations. 'Having your friends over is like entertaining at a big country house' (June, Yorkshire 1997).

The idea of playing bingo in the middle of a field on a hot summer day in July can seem

absurd. Two dozen households of varying ages set up at tables surrounded by an open field half full of vans and bordered by trees in full leaf and with open 'views' beyond, in Constable Country in East Anglia.

No, it's not the countryside that matters so much. Last weekend we were in this horrible little field and it was nothing ... It does help when you go somewhere and that's pretty. Sometimes there's fishing and we've been on nice long walks. The other week was really nice, deer walking around, forest all around us. (Sheila, Essex 1996)

Club Magazines tend to represent 'countryside' as pastoral, sites fringed by a wooded valley or riverside, alongside others 'convenient' for access and manouvre (En Route 1978: 12–13, 1982).³ The caravanner is depicted as traveller and as active participant at gatherings and activities.⁴ Caravanning has been promoted in stylish 'heritage' posters linked with historic sites (En Route 1976). A visit to a caravan site is objectified as 'The Site Experience' with a mixture of spectacle, travel and activities but provide little clue of what space means (Caravan Club 1996). Local clubs advertise rallies in a combination of notes on the rural setting and titles that figure what people do, for example, 'boozers', 'fireworks'. In practice, 'the view' matters, but only in part. Caravanning may happen in the 'countryside' but this 'countryside' combines things, people and what you are doing. The fields, the country, the outdoors can seem to offer endless opportunity for things to do, where, and how to feel. Going 'somewhere else'— even to a site one mile from home— matters as much because it signifies getting away and seems still to evoke romance remembered from caravanning's past *and* yet also be surrounded by familiar artefacts in fields. Anticipation is marked by places en route: 'Once

we're past Crook you feel different' (Andrew, Weardale 1997). Places signify numerous individual journeys of memory *and* of what you know happens when you arrive.

'The field' becomes more than simply being outdoors: 'in the middle of a field, in the middle of nowhere' (Derek, Essex 1998). 'Nowhere' is a space of escape and discovery. This can reveal very deep feelings in the way people engage themselves in an encounter with the spaces felt to be around them:

Caravanning, all of it makes me smile inside. I mean, everyone just comes down to the ford and just stands there and watches life go by. It's amazing how you can have pleasure from something like that. I just sit down and look and I get so much enjoyment out of sitting and looking and doing nothing. We wake up in the morning, open the bedroom door and you're like breathing air into your living ... We walk and talk ... I love to cycle and fish. (Tim, Weardale, 1997)

Tim's son copes better with his disability at the site. 'Sometimes you just sit down and look at the trees and things, it's nice to get to the quiet' (Jason, 14, Essex, 1996). 'Remember when you went to Bingo that day, across the river in spate after the storm' (Harry, Weardale).

This narrative suggests that people 'discover' 'the field' in different ways. The field emerges as a place to meet people, to manoeuvre the van, to experience escape, separation, freedom, to express oneself.

Interpretations

The places people use are walked over, discovered with both feet, leaned against, reached, rested on, enjoyed and endured. 'Enjoying the view' *looking* is combined with numerous other modes of practice (Game 1991; Jay 1993).

Material sensuality and images relate. Space is encountered in the way people feel about what they are doing. In its material configuration it can also bring to life memories and expectations, the content of magazines and their club folklore, producing new traces of significance for the spaces they occupy and for their memories (Ahearne 1996; Cosgrove 1984; de Certeau 1984; Matless 1995; Reville and Watkins 1996). The feeling body exceeds manipulative encounter and grasps a sense of the world, but not in a detached way.

Contexts are interwoven and negotiated. Making space is in looking, listening and touching, cultural and habit-based forms of what people do is simultaneously felt bodily (Crossley 1995: 57–60, 1996). Representations are embodied and drawn into a felt 'doing' and knowledge in practice, in what Shotter calls a contingent process of figuring out the world through inter-subjective practices (i.e. *practical knowledge*), which is learnt, acquired and wrestled with, and which has the potential to reconfigure our sense of the world and how things are done and our position in relation to them (*ontological knowledge*) (1993).

Recreational caravanning uses the potential of expressive self-discovery and of constructing and refiguring subjectivities (Crouch 1999). These can happen through moving around and doing different activities (contemplation). In these practices emotion, caring and relationships can be expressed bodily and spatially. In using objects in those spaces it appears possible to express inner identity and feeling, to others or to oneself. Media images can signify expression and suggest tendencies in modes of behaviour. People act and make sense; convey, engage, relate and express values and feelings of non-commodity relations and tenderness (Gorz 1984). The use of spaces in rituals can constitute a process of making identity, participating in cultural capital and making friends.

People can *imagine* romantic constituents of what community may be, but *join in* as embodied subjects; they like to *see themselves* in magazine photographs of other people because they know they do the same thing.

The subject's body becomes style and the *means* through which to express itself, as 'being', enjoying life, 'making fun'. Whilst adornment of the body can provide inscription of culture upon it, it can also be used as a facility through which the body extends the self metaphorically and sensuously into the world (Radley 1995). 'Fun' may be a means of being in the world, of reaching and engaging it; the subject declares herself in relation to it. Practice is not limited to the adoption of pre-coded modes of behaviour or a pre-disposed use of concrete objects even where these objects and their distinctive spaces both reassert memories and are freshly (re)invented. Through activities and dispositions, touch and movement, it is possible to express feeling, subjectivity and unique personality that endow spaces with particular value. The body can express its emotional relationship with—and in—its immediate surrounding world.

When people join in a game with others, stand and take in the surrounding space or sit in a deckchair they can be suspending cares, relaxing modes of being in a state of temporary bodily suspension between regimes of bodily activity and engagement. This space-ing is not only possible because fields are not their everyday spaces but because of what they do, there, through direct material contact with space in juxtaposition with memory, values and imagination. Emotional encounter with space can be imaginative and embodied (Lyon and Barbalet 1993: 58–62). Prior configurations of space and material objects can be refigured and felt to empower.

In several of the cases discussed space is subjectivised as the body expresses itself emo-

tionally and imaginatively in the space it feels and appropriates (de Certeau 1984: 97). 'Being lazy' can define an imaginative relaxed body-space, 'people simply standing by the river'. Sitting in a deck chair 'in the middle of a field' can provide a chance to reflect, to transform the everyday and also to renegotiate the everyday by the use of familiar artefacts and relationship-networks. People say this enables them to escape 'the humdrum'. This suggests a sense of deadened self, dulled imagination that is felt to contrast with what becomes possible caravanning: 'or else you'll be out washing the car, doing some gardening, hanging out the washing'. Conversely, what may be labelled 'chores' by some people can cease to be so when they are part of an enthusiasm.

Spatial practice includes rationality and objectivity but encounters deep feelings *and* surface play. 'Breathing air into your living', grown men and women just standing and staring, youth 'getting to the quiet' seem to exemplify the poetic bodily encounter. Space can be transformed in the process. Desire and imagination are practised and embodied through an encounter with the world, marked by concrete spaces (Radley 1990). Even 'when we are in the world of dreams we are still not disconnected from the world of intersubjective, perceptual experience' (Crossley 1996: 71).

Refiguring

The human subject lives in (relation to) contexts and their inscriptions on the body and on spaces, but *acts* as a human being. It is possible to draw away, progressively, from geography's tendency of masculinist reduction to acknowledge feminine practice (Rose 1993). The evident ('detached') view of men of a 'wider community ideal' is tempered by their *joining in*; women who seem to prioritize interactive

friendship feel secure in knowing their membership of a club. Women using objects from home sustains contact with the domestic everyday, but in contexts of their own making. The sensitivity expressed by Tim in Weardale does not evince a dominating masculinity of detached surveillance. He is aware of the importance of this place to his son's disability, and feels an expressive and sensuous engagement with space, reflecting a gentle and intimate celebration of what that place means through dimensions of the domestic everyday away. This suggests nuanced differences between feminine and masculine practice, not only between what men do and what women do.⁵

People inhabit and constitute spaces of power relations: embodiment provides 'necessary ground through which to rethink' them (Crossley 1995: 59–60). The apparent pre-discursive sensuous/expressive is made by subjects already embedded in a cultural world; they may act pre-discursively, but reflexively and discursively figure and refigure their sensuous/expressive and poetic encounters. Discursivity and subjectivity are complicated by simultaneous pre-discursive encounters. Through expressing, feeling, imagining our lives and their relations to others our grasp of the world is embodied subjectively and in a process in relation to inscribed semiotics. Space is practised and signified in relation to an expressive and sensuous embodied practice. Inscribed contexts can pre-dispose forms of expression but can be disrupted. Signs are constituted, produced, figured/refigured in a process of embodied semiotics. What emerges is a relational rather than relativist process and interpretation. The contents of practice can be negotiated.³

The interpretation of space, the outdoors, 'countryside' and 'nature' suggests a further unsettling of taken-for-granted cultural capital,

the power of context and pre-figured meanings in terms of spatial labelling (Hetherington 1998; Macnaghten and Urry 1998; Crouch 1992). There is instead negotiation in caravanners' making sense of space and in their making space. Preferences for 'a pretty village', to see deer and to stay at a more 'attractive' site suggest familiar images of countryside and nature. On the other hand, 'the countryside does not matter'; 'all you need is a few cans and a field'. The language is familiar, but its constitution often unexpected: field, countryside, sanctuary, community are often not coded in relation to context-explicit meanings. Their symbolism works through a practical *being* and *doing there* that may draw upon, practise and embody other semiotic vocabulary. There is an awareness of both *being* somewhere, of having semiotic reminders, but also of having something to *do*, an awareness of surrounding volume, objects and actions sensed, used, made sense in doing.

Everyday routes to knowledge/practice can be unsettled. Lay knowledge, context and practice merge in refigured ways. Although 'the view' matters, the 'field' is a site of practice. 'The outdoors' is a kaleidoscope of significations, where practice, body, friendship and play mix with ideas of something attractive and in a process of remaking subjectivities and identities (Crouch and Toogood 1999). There is, then, a negotiation of desired meanings and a play of memory, 'popular culture', household concerns and what people do and feel. These negotiations they take away with them and use to anticipate another visit. Memory is constantly refigured as it is worked in and through practice, in altered feelings and encounters and configurations of the material world (Csikszentmihalyi and Rochberg-Halton 1981). 'Detachment' is patchy and interrupted by emotions and influences from the 'everyday' and thus never simply 'outside'.

Spaces, contexts and representations are embodied in practice, through which people construct their spatialities. Whilst the idea of a field in the middle of nowhere suggests escape, that needs to be qualified, as it is about complex human subjective engagement. Moreover, it is life that matters, rendering practice and space part of an uneven web of ongoing interactions, meanings and adjustments. For example, for some caravanners a tradition of working-class rambling and camping patinaed with spatial images informs their ideology but this tradition, or context, was embodied as being outdoors engaged in smells, effort and relaxation.

It's a bit of a sanctuary. I don't think people started camping and caravanning for that sanctuary, it probably comes out of what you're doing because of what you're doing and because of the values you treasure and how you respect other people's space. (Denis, Yorkshire 1998)

This is a complex cultural practice where ideology does not pre-determine, but can be involved and be evolved through the practice.

This sensuous/expressive embodiment provides grounds for rethinking power relations, in gentle, everyday and accessible micro-politics. de Certeau's poetics/poesis concern everyday minutiae in the assertion of the self and in an exercise of everyday politics and so this practice offers a micro-politics of the everyday (from Ahearne 1996: 185). In the nuanced complexity of human relations there can be an exploration of non-commodity values. Sensuous/expressive embodiment provides further grounds through which the subject can be understood to encounter, rework and contest the world.

'Contexts' as pre-figured are fluid, interactive; powerful but not determining. Spatialities may 'proceed from a sense that (they are)

semi-detached, distinctive yet connected' from 'contexts' (Crouch and Matless 1996), but they are not pre-constituted. Thus suggests negotiation across the illusory 'gap' between representations and practices, the arena of embodied encounters, sensuous/expressive practice where space is in flux. Practice can 'make sense' of representations as everyday geographies. In pursuing the possible constitution of everyday spatialities it becomes necessary to acknowledge the possibility of embodiment as complicating apparently intellectual processes (Bachelard 1994; de Certeau 1984). Space is never ontologically given but developed through practices, discursively grasped in an embodied way. It thereby becomes important to re-write spatialities as *spacing*, practising and producing.⁶

Fields and fields: entities and identities

Lay geography emerges as an embodied semi-otics of dynamic multi-sensual and poetic patina. Our spatialities are, then, created and performed, and related to (other) contexts. These spatialities are performed for ourselves in constituting and refiguring our identities and in relation to the world, and performed for others in a practice of who we feel we are at the time. Thinking in terms of refiguring space provides a means to understand the spatial encounter people make as ones of unfolding, negotiation and contesting rather than constantly finding the world always unstable and overwhelming (Levinas 1961). Inter-relating the several aspects of embodiment theory extends our ability to make sense of these feelings and knowings of practised geographies. These spatialities are dynamic and partly refigure and displace representations around us. The value of practice and the knowledge it informs, and is informed by, are each semi-detached from these

'other' representations, themselves dynamic constituents of practice, distinct yet related.

Investigations of this kind inform our understanding of what leisure/tourism geographies can be, and how they are made (Crouch 1999). Our interviewees are not caravanners but human subjects, people who have various complex lives and may *use* caravanning's spaces as means to make sense of their lives, and make those spaces in terms of their lives. These spaces are not finite, but through them our subjects sought to make sense of their lives. They did so often by comparison with other spaces and through metaphor. These spaces and their embodied practice are time-dimensioned, sometimes felt time-suspended, ephemeral. Space-making is fractured across the day, between different actions and memories. Time becomes embodied.

The 'field' of ethnographic work is different, although it also encounters components of 'field' that the participants use. The material space in which caravanning is identified has an *a priori* clarity yet it is between the complexity of practice, metaphorical space, roughly edged physical materiality and the subjectivities of the researchers that the field of this research is established. Indeed, the field is not a 'space' until it is practised by people's active occupation, there is nothing 'given' about the field (Clifford 1997: 54).

Nast prioritizes what the field is and how it may be identified in political objectives (1994). Kobayashi calls *the field* a *social terrain* of academic, non-academic encounter *through direct experience, the academic foundation of knowledge* (1994: 73–80). Understanding of lay knowledge can ground academic knowledge and disrupt particular (male) academic traditions rather than a practice of intentional slumming (Katz 1994: 72). We are of course semi-detached (Katz 1994: 57). Our subjects are different from ourselves, as evident in our

experience as researchers. But at the same time we are not *pretending* to be the same, but claim to be able to understand through the nature of encounter constructed in the fieldwork. There is a possible translation here. Clifford identifies the *field* of inquiry as a bundle of loosely bounded practices that happen in relation to space/time, a site of research encounter (1997). What becomes researched as the field emerges as a site of constant negotiation, of the self, others, researcher and researched, subject/object/subject, through a process of uneven encounter.

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Notes

- 1 Masculinist geographies may have interpreted neither the living and feeling of men or of women very well (Rose 1993: 1).
- 2 Caravanning people use a van they either tow to a site or keep at the site, typically a space in the country rented from a farmer or other land owner. For practical reasons sites are near access points, on level land, and tend to be located near buildings that can be useful, like a pub. We investigated people who are members of a club (typically, a caravan club) and we worked through local branches of caravan clubs as a means to develop trust and prepare contacts. Club fixtures meant that they selected the sites not us.
- 3 See, for example, Jacobs 1971, Steib 1989.
- 4 See, for example, Patterson 1990.
- 5 Social differences can be marked in activities and objects. Working-class caravanners who live in Sunderland fringe estates and middle-class administrators in Suffolk talk about caravanning in ways that can be easily stereo-

typed. One speaks of the 'humdrum' and the other the need to be away from the phone. There is, however, a strong sense that their sensuous and expressive encounters, values about what they are doing and its poetic content complicate spatial distinctions constructed of cultural capital (Savage, Barlow, Dickens and Fielding 1992). Objects are used for display and to make exclusions and as resources for making interaction, enthusiasm and friendship, tenderness, humour.

Different participation in food preparation and the way in which men seem often to use barbecue for display mark gender but the spaces of eating provide conversation and friendship. Caravanning folklore is complex, part of wider contextualities: early twentieth-century upper middle-class car owners and working-class camping/rambling. Twentieth-century club magazines portrayed men doing things with the van or 'at ease' in a deckchair and women (often appearing in van doorways) as decorative, supportive. Some advertisements feature vans, models in deckchairs painting pictures of landscapes, decorative and middle class. Women tend to do the 'indoor work', men attend to motor equipment. Men emerge to 'man' [*sic*] the barbecue that can serve as a masculinist token of cooking: 'the men stand out there chatting and pretending to prepare ... I usually go out after a while and do the cooking' (Beryl, Sheffield 1997, with a sense of triumph). However, this fieldwork suggests caution in being reductive. Young argues that there are distinctly feminine ways of doing things as in *throwing like a girl*, yet understanding her daughter growing up brought her to modulate this contextuality as she observed her daughter negotiate practice in her encounters with the world (1990: 15).

6 I thank Martin Gren for this insight.

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Abstract translations

Pratiques spatiales et le sentiment de faire

Des discussions récentes portant sur les théories de la non-représentation et sur la pratique corporelle expressive/sensuelle ont ouvert des voies nouvelles permettant de repenser comment les gens vivent et ressentent, et d'enrichir les notions de pratique spatiale et géographie quotidienne. Dans cet article, je soutient cette proposition par le biais d'une eth-

nographie du caravaning de loisir au Royaume-Uni. J'examine comment des pratiques spatiales se développent à partir d'une refiguration de contextes et d'une sémiotique corporelle.

Mots clefs: pratique corporelle, espace, mise en espace.

Espacialidades y la sensación de hacer

Los últimos debates sobre la teoría no representativa y la práctica encarnada expresiva/sensual ofrecen nuevas orientaciones para reconsiderar cómo vive y cómo se siente la gente y también informan ideas de espacialidades y geografías legas. Estos argumentos los desarrollo en el papel por considerar una etnografía del 'caravaning' recreativo en el Reino Unido. Considero cómo se puede desarrollar espacialidades en la práctica con relación a una refiguración de contextos y la semiótica encarnada.

Palabras claves: encarnación, práctica, espacio, espacialización.